

SPERT® Story Map

Quick Reference Guide

Browser-based agile release planning with story map structure, sprint tracking, and insights · spert-story-map.vercel.app

WHAT IS SPERT® STORY MAP?

SPERT® Story Map is a browser-based agile release planning tool that replaces spreadsheet-driven story mapping workflows. It organizes work in a three-level hierarchy (**Theme** → **Backbone** → **Rib Item**) and connects your product backlog to releases, sprints, and progress tracking — all in one place. Use it to plan, size, assign, and track delivery of your product backlog across releases.

Theme	The highest-level grouping — a major capability area or product theme. Each theme can optionally be assigned a color for visual differentiation on the story map.
Backbone item	A feature or user activity under a theme. Backbone items span releases and contain rib items.
Rib item	The finest-grained work unit. Has a t-shirt size (XS → XXXL), a category (Core / Non-core), release allocations, and sprint-by-sprint progress tracking.
Release	A named delivery milestone with an optional target date. Rib items are assigned to releases with a percentage allocation (single release = 100%, or split across multiple releases).
Sprint	A time-boxed iteration with a name and end date. Used to record incremental progress on each rib item's release allocation.

■ Create your Themes, Backbones, and Rib Items in the Structure tab first — then assign them to releases in the Releases tab and track sprint progress in the Progress tab.

STEP-BY-STEP WORKFLOW

1 Projects	Create a product. Click New Product , give it a name and optional description. Products are listed as cards on the home screen.
2 Structure	Build your hierarchy. Add Themes , then Backbone items under each theme, then Rib items under each backbone. Assign a t-shirt size and Core/Non-core category to each rib item. Drag to reorder any level.
3 Settings	Configure Releases (delivery milestones with optional target dates) and Sprints (iterations with end dates and cadence). Set the Size Mapping (points per t-shirt size) and project details.
4 Releases	Assign rib items to releases via the Kanban board. Drag cards across columns. Use Split Allocation to divide a rib item's effort across multiple releases with percentage splits.
5 Progress	After each sprint, record percent-complete for each rib item per release. Select the sprint, enter progress values, and optionally add assessment notes. View burn-up charts and delta tracking.
6 Insights	Review analytics: total and per-release points, core/non-core breakdown, sizing distribution, burn-up chart over time, and attention items (unsized, unassigned, or partially allocated ribs).

VIEWS & KEY FEATURES

Structure tab	Grid editor for the Theme → Backbone → Rib hierarchy. Inline editing, drag-to-reorder, t-shirt size picker, and Core/Non-core toggle per rib item.
Map tab	Interactive visual story map with pan and zoom. Rib items appear as cards in a grid of backbone columns × release lanes. Drag ribs, backbones, or themes to reorder. Click a rib card or release label to open a slide-out detail panel.

Sizing tab	Drag-and-drop sizing board. Unsized items appear at the top; sized items sort into t-shirt size columns. Rib items with progress > 0% are locked to prevent re-sizing active work.
Releases tab	Kanban board — one column per release. Drag rib cards across columns to assign. Use Split Allocation to distribute a rib item's effort across multiple releases by percentage.
Progress tab	Sprint-by-sprint progress entry. Select a sprint, enter % complete per rib/release row. Group by release, backbone, or theme. View burn-up chart and delta from prior sprint. Add assessment notes to any progress entry.
Insights tab	Analytics dashboard: total/core/non-core points, rib count, % complete, per-release breakdown (core vs. non-core bars), sizing distribution, burn-up chart over time, and attention items.
Settings tab	Manage releases, sprints, sprint cadence, size mapping (points per t-shirt label), project name/description, data export/import, and (if enabled) cloud storage and project sharing.

RELEASE ALLOCATION & PROGRESS TRACKING

Single allocation	Drag a rib card into a release column to assign 100% of its effort to that release.
Split allocation	Click the split icon on a rib card to open the allocation editor. Distribute the rib's effort across multiple releases by percentage (must total 100%).
Progress entry	In the Progress tab, enter % complete for each rib item per release. Progress is tracked per-release per-sprint. Entering 0 or clearing removes the entry (unless a comment exists).
Delta tracking	The Progress tab shows the change in % complete since the prior sprint — helping the team see velocity and identify stalled items at a glance.
Burn-up chart	Displays cumulative completed points vs. total scope over sprints. Scope changes are reflected automatically as rib items are added, sized, or re-allocated.
Assessment notes	Each progress entry supports an optional comment. Notes are shown in an expandable panel with full history, newest-first.

■ Progress regression is allowed — you can reduce a rib item's % complete to keep data honest. Undo (Ctrl+Z) is available for all edits within the session but does not persist across page refreshes.

DATA & STORAGE

Local storage	Default. Data is stored in your browser only — never sent to any server. Safe for corporate data. Clearing browser site data will permanently delete all products. Use Export to back up.
Cloud storage	Optional. Sign in with Google or Microsoft. Data syncs via Firebase across all your devices and enables project sharing with team members (owner / editor / viewer roles).
Export / Import	(Settings tab → Data) Download a product as a JSON backup file, or import a previously exported file. Import supports skip, replace, or import-as-copy for naming conflicts.
Export for Forecaster	(Settings tab → Data) Export a product in SPERT® Release Forecaster import format — transforming releases into milestones with per-release backlog sizes and sprint velocity data.
Undo / Redo	Ctrl+Z / Ctrl+Shift+Z. Up to 30 undo steps, in-memory only. Undo history resets on page refresh.
Dark mode	Toggle light/dark/system via the sun/moon icon in the product header. Preference is saved to localStorage.

■ Export a backup before sharing a product file with colleagues or before major updates. The Export Attribution fields (Settings → App Settings ■) embed your name in exported files for team workflow traceability.

SIZE MAPPING & T-SHIRT SIZING

Rib items are sized using t-shirt labels that map to story points. The default mapping is configurable per product in **Settings** → **Size Mapping**. Points drive all calculations in the Insights and Progress tabs.

Size	Default Points	Notes
XS	5	Smallest unit — quick tasks, minor enhancements.
S	10	Small, well-understood feature with minimal unknowns.
M	20	Typical mid-size feature requiring design and test effort.
L	40	Large feature with meaningful complexity or dependencies.
XL	100	Very large feature; consider breaking into smaller rib items.
XXL	200	Epic-scale work — splitting is strongly recommended.
XXXL	300	Highest size tier. Use as a placeholder until fully decomposed.

■ Rib items with progress > 0% are locked in the Sizing tab and cannot be re-sized. Resize before recording sprint progress, or clear the progress entry first.

TIPS, SHORTCUTS & ATTENTION ITEMS

Inline rename	Click any theme, backbone, rib item, or release label directly to rename it in-place. Press Enter to confirm or Escape to cancel.
Map pan & zoom	On the Map and Sizing tabs, click and drag any empty area to pan; mouse wheel or pinch to zoom. Double-click a release label to rename it; single-click opens its detail panel.
Drag to reorder	Structure tab: drag themes, backbones, and rib items. Map tab: drag rib cards (2D — across release lanes and backbone columns simultaneously), backbone headers (horizontal), or theme headers (horizontal). Releases tab: drag columns to reorder releases.
Undo / Redo	Ctrl+Z undoes the last edit; Ctrl+Shift+Z redoes. Up to 30 steps, in-session only. Undo history resets on page refresh.
Collapse themes	In the Structure tab, click a theme's collapse toggle to hide its backbones and ribs — useful on large products with many themes.
Attention items	The Insights tab flags three categories: Unsize d (no t-shirt size), Unassigned (not in any release), and Partially allocated (percentages sum to less than 100%). Resolve all three for accurate point totals and burn-up data.
Theme colors	Assign one of 8 colors (blue, teal, violet, rose, amber, emerald, indigo, orange) to each theme in the Structure tab. Colors carry through to the Map tab.
Export for Forecaster	Export the product to SPERT® Release Forecaster format (Settings → Data) to feed release backlog sizes and sprint velocity into an agile release forecast.

■ Use the Insights Attention Items panel as a pre-release health check: zero unsize, zero unassigned, and zero partially-allocated rib items means your release plan is fully specified and all point calculations are accurate.